University of Roue-Normandie

Module : Professional English

Professor : Mr.Tortuyaux

Subject: Critical evaluation and analyze of a digital humanities project

Title of The Assignment:

Critical analysis of the website Fashion History Timeline

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Presentation of The Fashion History Timeline:

The Fashion History Timeline is a priority project of the History of Art Department developed by the Fashion Institute of Technology (FIT) in New York. Initially launched in 2015 as a pilot initiative created by FIT Art History faculty and students.

It is a digital humanities project that currently includes 543 author contributions, 955 essays, 5404 fashion-history sources stored in a Zotero database, and 5100 visitors a day.

As its title clearly indicates, the website focuses on presenting the fundamental aspects and content of fashion history.

It is an open-source website dedicated to the world of fashion and textiles, featuring objects, artworks, garments, and visual materials from different centuries, decades and stylistic periods from the ancient world to the modern 21st century. It highlights the development of fashion and clothing across different continents such as Africa, Asia, Europe and Americas.

The website respects the four main conditions of a successful digital project, often summarized by the FAIR principles: the site is easily findable through simple online searches, fully accessible without requiring any account, payment, or identification, and interoperable thanks to its standardized metadata and integration with external tools such as Zotero, which makes all bibliographic sources easily exportable, and it is reusable in a logical way, allowing users to cite, export and build upon its content.

It is a global project that touches on many aspects of fashion through different historical periods. It includes resources related not only to garments and costumes but also to films, visual culture, and artworks.

The Timeline aims to be a valuable contribution to public knowledge of fashion and dress history, accessible not only for students, faculty and researchers but also to anyone interested in the evolution of clothing and style.

I find this website especially engaging because it combines several disciplines: fashion history, visual culture, and even a form of fashion archaeology, which is illustrated through the images and art facts provided, all of which are well explained on the platform.

The report examines the Fashion History Timelines both as a digital product and as a scholarly resource. It evaluates the website's narrative coherence, visual design, information structure and architecture, and academic credibility, and finally my own experience as a user. Through this analysis, I aim to determine whether the website successfully fulfills its mission as a digital humanities platform and how effectively it supports independent research in fashion studies.

Beyond the technical aspects, this work also includes a personal reflection on my navigation of the site highlighting what surprised and attracts me, what helped me to understand the material, and what difficulties I encountered, all contributing to an objective analysis.

Main page structure:

The logo of the Fashion History Timeline is displayed at the top of the main page. The navigation menu, with its different hyperlinks, is placed near the top, allowing users to access the main sections of the site, including About, Time Period, Essays, Dictionary, Designers, and Source Database.

The three first sections (About, Time Period, and Essays) contain an arrow to show more details and options. For example, the Time Period section is very well detailed and structured, covering the most ancient decades to the most recent, which is very useful and practical for users. The structure is clear and easy to use, allowing smooth browsing without struggles. We don't feel lost at all, because every section and option is clearly described, and the layout looks like a fashion magazine.

Clicking on the About hyperlink leads to the How to Research Fashion section, which is a great feature. It shows users the procedures and steps to follow in a simple way, allowing easy navigation on the website and deeper exploration of fashion history.

One of the most interesting parts in this section, is the Museum Collections, which invite users to discover different designers, accessories, design objects, decorative items, textile, and fashion-related sites, including another section about fashion journals and articles. All these collections came from different continents and parts of the world: Americas, Asia, and Europe.

For example, the Bata Shoe Museum in Toronto. The site also includes online resources, such as runway images and designer biographies (e.g., British Vogue *Biographies*, n.d., http://www.vogue.co.uk/topic/biography. Permitting users to navigate directly from one site to another with a single click.

The How to Research Fashion section guides users directly toward their goal, opening the doors to the wide universe of fashion research.

Another important subsection under the About hyperlink is How to Contribute. The website is not crowdsourced; it is very structured and requires contributors to follow strict guidelines. Only people working in the fashion field or studying fashion history can become contributors; these conditions make the site a private and specialized resource.

At the end of the section, there are Site Timeline and Sitemap (after clicking on them), which structure the main page in a more classic and simple way, showing pages and categories along with different dates, months and years.

The homepage primarily showcases thumbnails of images and objects, giving users a visual overview of the available content. Each thumbnail can be clicked on the title to reveal a larger, full-size image, often accompanied by descriptive text, historical context, and bibliographic references. This combination of thumbnails and detailed views allows users to explore a large corpus efficiently, even on a standard computer screen.

The content is organized both chronologically and thematically, enabling users to navigate by historical period, geographical region, or type of artifact. Despite the richness of the material,

the layout remains clean and accessible, making it possible to examine hundreds of documents without feeling overwhelmed.

Overall, the homepage interface balances visual appeal and functionality, providing both immediate access to highlights and the option for deeper, scholarly exploration or research.

The analysis of each category and section of the Fashion History timeline:

Designers section:

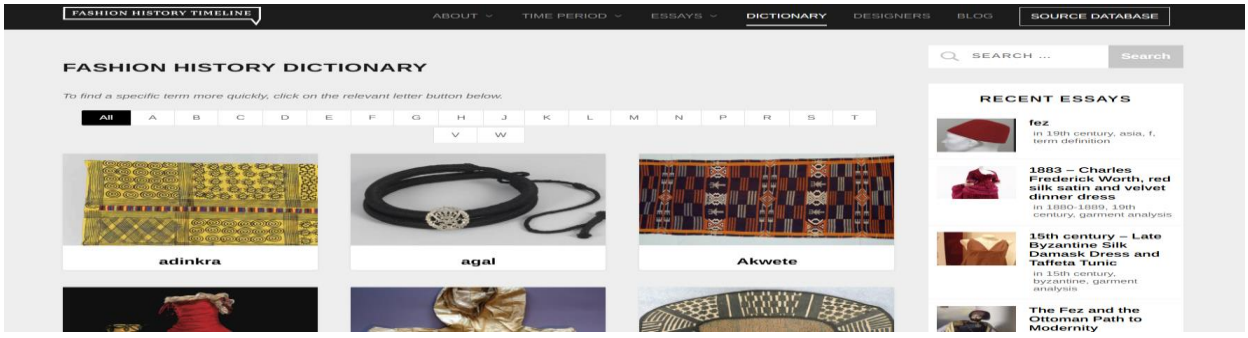
The designer's section presents some of the most emblematic designers in the world as well as the very first ones in history. For example: the designer Elizabeth Keckley (1818-1907) was the first African American women to become a dressmaker in 19th century in The United States of America, during the era of slavery against people of color. This kind of fact is very interesting because it combines historical and social aspects while allowing users to discover designers and learn new stories beyond the history of fashion.

For every designer presented on the Fashion History Timeline, their life and career are told storytelling, in a concise and well-structured summary. The presentation combines many aspects, especially highlighting what the designer contributed to the fashion world during their decade and what they added or created. We find many inspiring designers and figures who not only contributed to fashion but also to politics and society.

Additionally, these designers are often lesser-known or not celebrities, so the website puts the spotlight on them. In the fashion universe, there are stars like Coco Chanel, Yves Saint Laurent, and Versace, but these lesser-Known designers remain unknown to many people, even those working in fashion. Thus, reading about them and learning what they contributed to this field is a real discovery.

The Dictionary:

The dictionary hyperlink section provides an alphabetical index from A to W, where users can find all the types and formats of **garments** and clothing discussed on the website. Which greatly facilitates research. It is enough to click on the first letter of the object that you are looking for. They have adopted, in a way, the format of a real dictionary. There are not all the alphabetic letters; this structure and format giving it a classy, digitized version of design and appearance.



For example, if we want to discover the story of the **chaperon,** a turban-like headdress worn during the Middle Ages in western Europe, we simply click on the letter **C,** and all articles on clothes starting with that letter will appear. This section is designed specifically for clothing and accessories, shoes, etc., presenting their first appearance and historical context. Each entry provides a summary and detailed information about the item's creation, along with images, including ancient illustrations and even paintings of the articles published.

For instance, the article about the chaperon includes the Portrait of ***Giovanni Arnolfini*** painted by **Jan Van Eyck,** where Arnolfini is depicted wearing the headdress. Through this entry, users not only learn about garment itself but also about its history, related artworks, and painters, creating a rich, multidimensional understanding of the object.

Portrait of Giovanni Arnolfini (1434) - Jan Van Eyck

Authors category and Crowdsourcing:

Moreover, in the About hyperlink under-sections, there is the Authors section, this permits us as users and navigators to find all the contributors to the website, along with their field of study or profession, or both if it is the case, their profile image, full names, the number of posts, blogs and articles they have written, and their specialization on the field of the fashion history.

The authors are organized from those who have written the most posts to those with the fewest. In this case, the first author listed is Justine De Young with 27 posts, while the last one on the list is Jaqueline Carvalho with 0 posts.

Clicking on an author's name leads users to a page that gathers all their published posts. Some authors even share their social media accounts, giving a more visual and academic connection to the contributor. This allows users to follow them easily if they are interested in their field of research or simply enjoying their content.

This site treats all authors equally, without marginalizing any contributors.

In this category, there is also a part called FIT Students, which represents the anonymous and collaborative contributions of FIT Students enrolled in History of Art courses. Here, all anonymous posts are separated from those identified authors.

The time period category:

The time period hyperlinks are very detailed and structured, spanning from the ancient world to the modern era. It begins with ancient civilizations, including Prehistoric, Sumerian, Assyrian, Egyptian, Minoan, Greek, Etruscan, and Roman cultures. It then continues through the Middle Ages, from the earliest periods to the Byzantine era, and progresses through the Middle Ages centuries from the 14th century to the 21st century. Each century is further divided into periods; for example, in the19th century, 1860-1869 is treated as its own period with its own style, lifestyle and trends, highlighting the most dominant or innovative clothing of the time back then and they apply the same principle to the others periods as well.

Similarly, in the 20th century, 1990-1999 is noted for fashion becoming more casual for men, women and children. We discover Iconic garments and styles from this period are illustrated, such as the famous yellow costume worn by the main actress in ***Clueless (1955),*** designed by Mona May, which became a major fashion hit. The site shows these periods with authentic images from time as well as contemporary photographs, providing a chronological summary of fashion across the decades and demonstrating how styles have evolved over the centuries.

Clueless (1955), movie

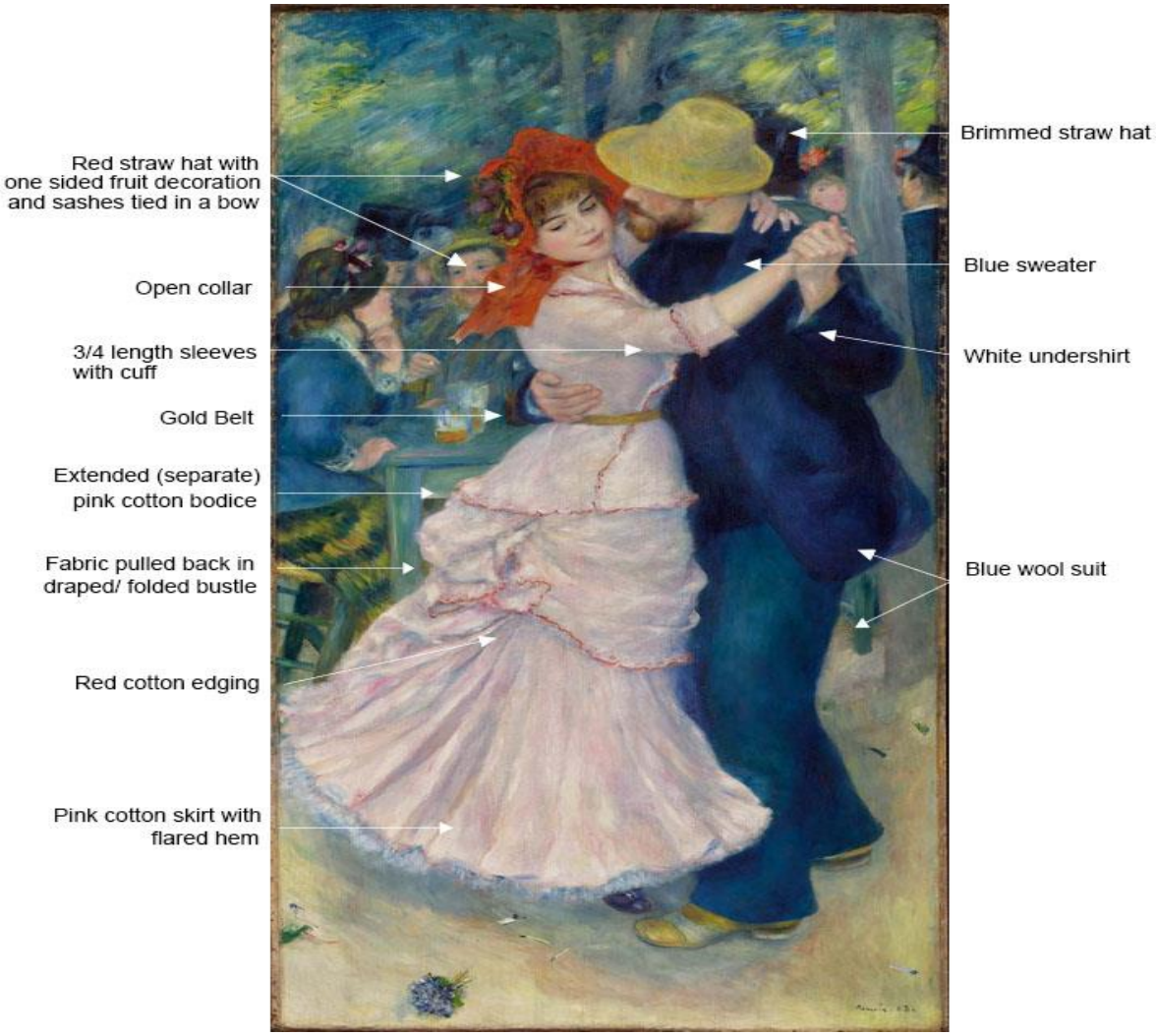
ESSAY Categories

Artwork:

The essays category is intended to analyze fashion across various fields and domains of art, including artwork, garments, film, and thematic studies.

In the artwork section, we find almost all the major painting movements, the most famous portraits and paintings, and prominent painters throughout the ages. The writers of the website also analyze the clothing depicted in these paintings and portraits, as fashion and garments were transmitted visually before the invention of photography, through painting, which serve as inclusive and enduring works of art, fashion history and their works.

For example, the famous Impressionist movement and the major painters are highlighted, such as Pierre-August Renoir, with works like ***Dancer at Bougival*** (1883) and ***City Dance*** (1883). Also, the renowned Edouard Manet, with ***Th Balcony*** (1868-1869), are analyzed in terms of the fashion depicted in paintings.



Dancer at Bougival (1883)- Pierre-August Renoir.

These sections demonstrate the crucial role that artwork and paintings played in fashion history, conserving styles and garments before the invention of photography.

In result, many designers, stylists and pattern makers have later drawn inspiration from these painted garments. Notably the portrait Madame X (Virginie Gautreau) (1884) by John Singer Sargent.

This analysis allows us to discover another dimension of the relationship between art, paintings, and fashion, showing how artworks contribute to the studies, preservation, and inspiration of fashion across centuries.

FILM ANALYSIS:

The Film Analysis category of Fashion History Timeline is particularly rich and engaging as it studies and examines the appearance of fashion and dresses on the big screen throughout cinema history. I found this section especially fascinating because it demonstrates how films have historically shaped, reflected and transmitted fashion trends, highlighting the connection between costume designed, social context, and cultural influence.

This section is organized into clear analytical steps, which include Ensemble Costume, Analysis, Period Setting, and Costume Design. This structure allows the reader to understand both the visual and historical context of the garments portrayed in films.

For example, the analysis of ***The Opposite Sex*** shows the film benefitted from the same art director and set decorator who related the world of the Women 1939, linking costume designed to cinematic legacy. Similarly, the website examines iconic films as ***Cleopatra,*** which for the first time back then showcased the makeup; jewelry became trends. Illustrate how film costumes can have a lasting impact beyond the screen.

I particularly appreciated how the film section emphasizes women's fashion, showing both historical and stylistic developments in detail. However, I noticed that the evolution of men's fashion receives significantly less attention, which limits the completeness and inclusivity of the analysis provided on the website. Despite this point, the Film Analysis section successfully demonstrates the power of cinema as a medium for both documenting and inspiring fashion trends across different periods and regions.

Cleopatra (1963 movie)

BIOPOC and LGBT+ Categories:

BIPOC: Black, Indigenous, and People of Color

this category explores, across different eras, the fashion and style of black, indigenous and other People of color, not only through portraits and documentary sources, but also via the work of designers of color who have contributed their own aesthetic to global fashion. It analyses distinctive garments (for example the "**Dashiki**") and traces how such items, initially rooted in specific cultural or ethnic identities, have been adopted, transformed and globalized.

The project thus sheds light on how fashion belonging to marginalized or nonwestern communities has impacted the broader fashion world, influencing trends, challenging Eurocentric standards, and asserting cultural identity.

Portrait of a Youth in an Embroidered Vest (1785)- Marie-Victoire Lemoine.

LBTQ + Category:

This category aims to highlight the contributions of LGBTQ+ designers and the influence of queer cultures on the evolution of style. It addresses nonheteronormative identities. Although the number of articles currently limited, this category signals how gender and sexuality intersect with dress, and how fashion can be a medium of identity expression, resistance and community.

Including BIPOC and LGBT+ categories in a Fashion History Timeline is a powerful way to democratize the study of dress. It moves beyond a narrow, often Western-centric historiography and acknowledges multiplicity, of cultures, identities and experiences. Yet the relative scarcity of articles suggests that there is still much work to be done.

The project would benefit from deeper and more systematic research: more essays covering non-Western periods, regional fashion histories and lived experiences communities. Through this process The Timeline could better reflect the true diversity of global fashion history, and challenge dominant narratives.

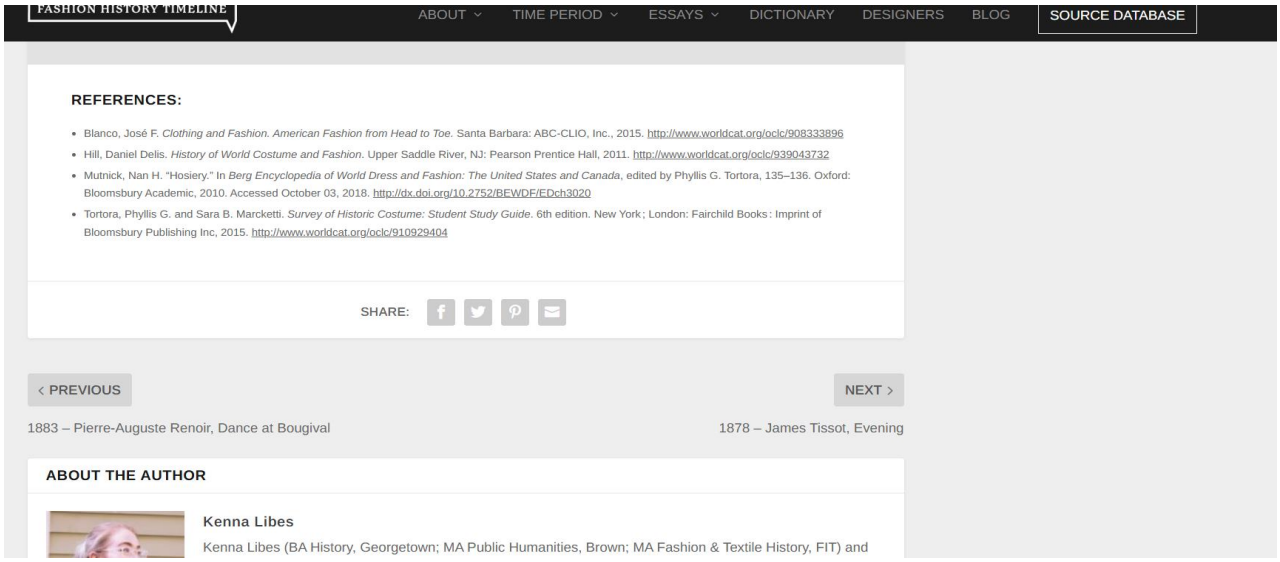
The articles writing structure:

The articles are written in an inverted pyramid structure; they follow the same pattern most of the time. For example, the two latest articles about THE RED DRESS and 15TH Century Late Byzantine Silk Damask start by presenting the title, followed by a lead paragraph that offers a brief introduction.

About the look section, they explain the story of the object: when and where it was found and by whom, they answer the five important questions (5W). Moreover, the writers give more details about the dress or the object they are describing, and they include pictures and images to illustrate it, which gives life and interest to the article and enriches storytelling with factual elements.

The second major title is About the context, in this part, the author relates the entire story in greater depth and provides more detailed information, accompanied by real quotations and properly listed references.

The structure of the articles, combined with 'Next' and 'Previous' navigation buttons, creates an experience reminiscent of a magazine layout, allowing users to seamlessly move between articles and topics while maintaining continuity and ease of reading.



Blog Category:

In the Blog category, the number of articles is relatively limited. Most of these texts align with the themes developed in other essays on the site, and they tend to focus on emblematic figures in fashion history. For instance, we find articles about personalities such as *Farida Kahli,* whose distinctive aesthetic, has left an unexpected mark on the fashion world.

The topics addressed also explore various forms of stylistic revolution. This section is characterized by a distinctly modern orientation: most of the analysis concentrates on the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, setting it apart from previous categories, which are more strongly rooted in earlier periods of fashion history.

Website Design and Usability:

The Fashion History Timeline is a modern and pleasant website to navigate and browse in, with a visually appealing layout and beautiful images. It has a classic dimension, and the titles are clear, while the language used throughout the site is easy to understand. The content is well

guided, and the structure is well organized, presenting information clearly. Navigation is straight forward, making it very easy to find the main sections of the site.

However, not all images and thumbnails are perfectly integrated into text; some have poor dimensions or low quality, which can slightly interrupt the reading experience. The search engine does not work very efficiently, and there are no filtering options. This limitation is understandable, given that the content is limited and focused on a specific field which is fashion, unlike larger databases such as books collections for example: *Project of Gutenberg.* Overall, the website is enjoyable to explore, providing a guided user experience.

The website's hyperlinks are clearly labeled and intuitively placed, allowing users to navigate easily between sections. Clicking on a link reliably directs the user to the relevant content, facilitating smooth exploration of the Fashion History Timeline content.

Humanities Involved in the project:

This project intersects with several fields within humanities. First, it is fundamentally rooted in history as it is mentioned in its title, since fashion is deeply connected to the social, political, and economic contexts. Historical events, such as industrialization, colonial expansion, world wars, or liberation movements, have all directly or indirectly influenced the evolution of clothing, materials, and aesthetic values.

The project also engages with geography, which plays a crucial role in shaping fashion across different cultures and regions. It explains why certain fabrics and styles originate from specific places before spreading globally. By examining fashion through a geographical lens, the timeline highlights how clothes evolve through contact between regions, continents, countries, and global interactions.

In addition, fashion history cannot be separate from art history, since before the rise of photography and media, clothing was preserved and presented through paintings, portraits, and later cinema, museums and visual archives allow us to study past garments and understand how fashion was perceived and idealized.

Similarly, anthropology contributes essential insights, revealing how dress functions as a maker of identity, ritual, status, and belonging across societies and generations.

Altogether, the project demonstrates that fashion is a global, interdisciplinary field. It grows through constant interaction with other cultural and artistic art, cinema, photography, literature, museums studies and these disciplines complete one another creating a diverse cultural and aesthetic world. Fashion is therefore not an isolated practice, but a complex cultural phenomenon shaped by multiple formas of human expression and creativity.

Finally, the project incorporates elements of gender studies, given the role of fashion in constructing and expressing gender identities, as well as media and visual studies, since the communications and dissemination of style rely heavily on evolving media technologies.

Mobile Accessibility and Responsiveness:

Concerning the Fashion History Timeline, when consulting the website on a mobile phone, the layout becomes vertical and much more compact. The thumbnails change in size, appearing smaller and more tightly arranged. At the top of the page website, users can access the language-switch option, which allows translation into French language but not into other languages. Overall, the structure remains consistent with the desktop version, with no major changes. The site is also easily accessible and readable on a mobile device.

Conclusion and Critical Evaluation:

The Fashion History Timeline is a well-structured, visually appealing, and academically reliable resource that provides users with a comprehensive view of fashion across centuries. The site successfully combines scholarly essays, curated timelines, dictionary entries, designers profiles, and visual documentation to offer multiple perspectives on the evolution of dress, style, and cultural practices. It's organization, clear navigation, and thoughtfully designed for users, whether exploring historical garments, iconic designers, or fashion-related artworks and films.

While the platform excels in covering historical fashion, particularly from Renaissance through 21st century. The focus remains largely on older periods, and contemporary fashion evolution is relatively underrepresented. Expanding the scope to include the progression of modern fashion trends, particularly those influenced by digital innovation and artificial intelligence, would enhance the relevance of the site for current studies. Additionally, creating more articles on contemporary fashion topics could balance the depth of historical content with insights into present–day developments.

Although new posts are not added continuously, the website demonstrates that it remains an active and dynamic resource. For instance, the most recent update-an essay titled Fez- was updated on November 10, 2025. The presence of a dedicated section highlighting recent topics further confirms that the site is alive and continues to engage with ongoing research and contemporary discussions in the field of fashion studies.

The decision or the option not to adopt crowdsourcing ensures a high level of credibility and reliability, as contributions are restricted to scholars and professionals in the field. This policy reinforces the authority of information and maintains academic standards, preventing the dilution of content quality.

However, opening avenues for controlled contributions, such as peer-reviewed submissions or collaborations with students and scholars, could enrich the site without compromising its rigor and standards.

Notably, the website caters to a broad, multi-disciplinary audience. It is not limited to scholars or professionals in fashion history; casual users, students, or anyone with a general interest in culture and style can navigate and learn from the site.

This inclusivity is a distinguishing feature compared to more specialized platforms, or site web as ***THE VALLEY OF THE SHADOW,*** which target a specific academic and may be inaccessible or less engaging for casual users. In contrast, the Fashion History Timeline

successfully balances scholarly rigor with accessibility, allowing a wide range of users to discover, explore, and gain knowledge, even out of general curiosity.

Finally, one of the fundamental principles of digital project design is encapsulated in **Steve Krug**'s usability theory ***Don't Make Me Think*** (2000), which argues that a successful website must be intuitive, self-explanatory, and cognitively effortless for the user. In this respect, the Fashion History Timeline largely respects this principle: it's clear structure readable layout, and logical navigation allow users to access information without confusion or unnecessary effort.

In summary, the Fashion History Timeline represents a robust and interdisciplinary digital humanities project that effectively integrates history, art, anthropology, and visual culture. While its primary strength lies in its historical depth and scholarly precision, future development could include broader coverage of modern fashion, integration of IA assisted research insights, and selective contributions from a wider scholarly community to ensure continued relevance and inclusivity.